

Animal Welfare Policy

Protecting the welfare of animals involved in our provision

15-17 Irlam Road, Bootle, Liverpool, L20 4AE · Alternative Provision for Ages 5–25

ADOPTED POLICY

This policy has been formally adopted by L-Fit Pathways' co-directors and is in effect from the date shown below. Any section still shown in [square brackets and amber text] is organisation-specific detail that remains to be confirmed and inserted - it does not affect the rest of the policy's validity but should be completed as soon as possible.

Version: 1.0 (Adopted)

Date Adopted: 16 September 2026

Next Review Due: 16 September 2027 (or sooner following any legislative change or relevant incident)

1. Statement of Intent

L-Fit Pathways does not own, house or keep animals itself. Animal Assisted Learning sessions are delivered in partnership with an outsourced, specialist AAL provider who supplies and cares for the animals involved. L-Fit Pathways is nonetheless committed to the welfare of any animal involved in our provision, in line with the Animal Welfare Act 2006, and only works with providers who meet the standards set out in this policy. Good animal welfare and good safeguarding go hand in hand — an animal that is calm, healthy and well cared for is essential to safe, effective sessions.

2. Legal Framework

- Animal Welfare Act 2006 — the duty to ensure the five welfare needs of any animal in our care
- Our outsourced Animal Assisted Learning provider is responsible for holding any local authority animal activity licence required under the Animal Welfare (Licensing of Activities Involving Animals) (England) Regulations 2018 for their own animals and activities. L-Fit Pathways checks that a current licence (where applicable) and appropriate insurance are in place before booking any session, and keeps a copy on file.

3. The Five Welfare Needs

- A suitable environment
- A suitable diet
- The ability to exhibit normal behaviour patterns
- Appropriate housing with, or apart from, other animals
- Protection from pain, suffering, injury and disease

4. Animal Care Standards

The animals used in Animal Assisted Learning sessions are owned, housed and cared for by our outsourced AAL provider, not by L-Fit Pathways. Day-to-day responsibility for each animal's diet, housing, veterinary care and the five welfare needs sits with that provider. L-Fit Pathways' responsibility is to select and continue working only with providers who can evidence appropriate

licensing, insurance and animal welfare standards, and to supervise the safety and wellbeing of young people throughout every session.

5. Handler Qualifications & Supervision

All Animal Assisted Learning sessions are led by a trained handler supplied by our outsourced provider, who is responsible for reading the animal's welfare and behaviour throughout the session, and for pausing or ending a session if the animal shows signs of stress. L-Fit Pathways confirms the provider's handler qualifications, DBS status, insurance and licensing before booking, and a member of L-Fit Pathways staff is present throughout every session for safeguarding purposes.

6. Interaction Rules

- Young people are briefed on safe, respectful handling before any contact with an animal
- Sessions are structured to give the animal regular rest periods away from young people
- Hand-washing and hygiene measures are followed before and after contact — see our Health & Safety Policy

7. Incident Procedure

Any incident involving an animal — whether an injury to a young person, a welfare concern, or unexpected animal behaviour — is recorded, reported to a Designated Safeguarding Lead, and reviewed to determine whether the animal, activity or environment needs to change before sessions resume.

8. Roles & Responsibilities

The Co-Directors hold overall responsibility for selecting and continuing to work only with outsourced AAL providers who meet the standards in this policy, and for the safeguarding and supervision of young people during every session. Day-to-day animal welfare responsibility sits with the outsourced provider's trained handler(s).

9. Monitoring & Review

This policy is reviewed annually, or sooner following an animal welfare or safety incident.

Policy adopted on: 16 September 2026 — Next review due: 16 September 2027